

The qualification path for Defence Canada work

What KOR must do — in order, with timelines — to be allowed to win DND work. The market is already mapped (June sector report); this is the how-to-qualify companion.

01 · THE ANSWER IN ONE PARAGRAPH

You can't apply cold — and you don't need to

Since the 2022 reform, a firm **cannot self-initiate** a federal security clearance: it must be **sponsored against a live requirement** — and both DCC itself (by email, citing a posted solicitation) and a cleared design-build prime with an active sensitive contract can sponsor a sub-consultant. Critically, **primes may not require an existing clearance to include KOR on a forming team** — teams are named first, clearances follow. So the play is: do the free week-zero registrations now, get named on teams (one is already forming), and trigger sponsorship the week it happens. The long pole is organization screening: **2–4 months** for the basic level, **6+ months** for the full facility clearance — which is exactly why starting before the next RFP matters.

02 · WHERE KOR ALREADY STANDS

The pursuits this readiness serves

LIVE THREAD	STATUS	WHY IT MATTERS HERE
CFB Esquimalt A/B Jetty Recapitalization	Team forming now — Yellowridge (GC) + DHK Architects + KOR structural + Islander/Gwaii civil (Rory)	The sponsorship vehicle. A naval jetty plausibly demands full facility clearance + Secret personnel — the per-contract security checklist (SRCL) decides; DCC states it in the advance notice before each RFP
19 Wing Comox cluster	Hangar (\$253M) awarded — prime picking subs; simulator + housing in flight	One DCC Pacific relationship (named contact on file) unlocks four programs
CFB Edmonton CFHA Housing Ph 2	RFP expected fall 2026 (~\$459M, ~1,010 units)	Bird built Phase 1 — the incumbent prime to court; KOR Edmonton alignment. Clearance-ready by fall = the point of starting now

The June sector report holds the full eight-project pipeline with verdicts and contacts; nothing there is repeated here.

03 · THE CLEARANCE SYSTEM, PLAINLY

Two levels for the firm, two for the people

LEVEL	WHAT IT ALLOWS	TIMELINE	COST
DOS — Designated Organization Screening	Protected-level work; personnel screened to Reliability	~2–4 months	Free (fingerprints ~\$40–65/person)
FSC — Facility Security Clearance (Secret)	Classified work; personnel to Secret	~6+ months (3–9 end-to-end reported)	Free
Reliability status (person)	The baseline for most design work	Weeks (fast once the org is cleared)	—
Secret (person)	Classified files; typically 2–3 key engineers	Months	—

- **Which one does KOR need?** There is no discipline-level rule — each contract's *Security Requirements Check List* decides. Protected-B design work → DOS; the jetty file plausibly demands FSC + Secret people. Plan for FSC; celebrate if DOS suffices.
 - **Sponsorship mechanics:** DCC sponsors directly — an email to its industrial-security sponsorship address citing the posted solicitation number — or a CSP-registered prime with an active sensitive contract sponsors its sub. Submit *the week a team names KOR*, not at award.
 - **Inside KOR, two roles must exist first:** a Company Security Officer (CSO) and alternate (ACSO) — a designation plus training, not a hire. This can be decided today.
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04 • THE OTHER GATES

Registrations, controlled goods, Indigenous content, cyber

- **CanadaBuys / SAP Business Network — free, do it today.** DCC posts everything on MERX (CanadaBuys mirrors); there is *no passive DCC supplier registry* — entry is competed A&E source-list solicitations or riding a prime's team. Note: the legacy federal supplier system (SRI) shut down **this very week** — one question for the CanadaBuys desk about the old business-number linkage.
- **Controlled Goods Program: almost certainly NOT needed** for structural design of jetties/hangars — the controlled-goods schedule has no infrastructure category. It's a per-contract checkbox; ask DCC when the jetty SRCL appears. If ever triggered: self-initiated (no sponsor), ~32+ business days, currently backlogged.

- **Indigenous participation: KOR's team is already the answer.** The 5% federal target is DCC's obligation, flowing down through prime-held Indigenous Benefits Plans — primes ask subs for Indigenous content, and DCC ran **12.8%** Indigenous value last fiscal year. The Islander/Gwaii civil partnership on the jetty team is precisely the card those plans want. Expect these clauses on everything Esquimalt/Comox.
- **Watch — cyber certification (CPCSC):** mandatory in select federal contracts from **summer 2026** (Level 2 spring 2027). Whether it reaches structural sub-consultants is unverified; cheap to track, expensive to be surprised by.

05 • THE CRITICAL PATH

What happens, in order, and who owns it

1

This week — no sponsor needed

Register on CanadaBuys/SAP (BD, ~an hour). Name the CSO + ACSO (Ian decides). Pre-draft the org-screening application. Set MERX/advance-notice alerts for DCC Pacific + Western. Email DCC the two clarifying questions: jetty SRCL level, and controlled-goods applicability.

2

The moment a team names KOR

Sponsorship submitted that week — via DCC (citing the solicitation) or the prime. The jetty team (Rory) is the nearest vehicle; the Comox primes and Bird-Edmonton are the next two conversations, and clearance-in-progress is a legitimate answer on a bid.

3

The long pole runs

Org screening: 2–4 months (DOS) to 6+ (FSC). After it clears and work is awarded: Reliability screening for the project engineers (weeks), Secret for 2–3 key people (months). Being mid-pipeline by fall = credible for Edmonton Phase 2.

Everything free and unsponsored starts this week; the clearance clock can only start when a team names us — so the fastest path to Defence work is the same as always: **get on the teams**. The jetty team already has us. Protect it.

What's solid and what needs one human check

- **Solid:** the no-cold-application rule (2022 reform), DCC + prime sponsorship routes, the timeline ranges, CanadaBuys/MERX mechanics, the Indigenous flow-down, CGP's likely non-applicability.
- **Needs one logged-in browser session:** the federal CSP/CGP pages block automated access — verbatim confirmation of the current application forms, plus a MERX pull of a recent DCC consultant RFP for exact insurance floors and Indigenous-plan clause language. Twenty minutes of human clicking closes both.
- **Decided per-contract, not researchable:** the jetty's actual clearance level (the advance notice will state it) and CPCSC's reach into structural files.